

film review

Disconnected

THE BONG CONNECTION

Director: Anjan Dutt
Starring: Raima Sen, Shyan Munshi, Parambrata Chatterjee, Peeya Rai Chowdhary

"We are global citizens," a character declares in *The Bong Connection*. "The whole world belongs to Bongs." So the film, ostensibly the first Bengali cross-over movie, traces two journeys—one of a Kolkata boy who declares that "Kolkata is a doomed Titanic" and moves to Texas and the other of a New York Bengali who moves to Kolkata to find his voice as a Baul musician. Both these 20-something boys struggle to make emotional, spiritual and cultural connections in new spaces. It's not easy. Within days, the Kolkata boy gets

mugged, discovers that his boss is homophobic and his roommate is gay. On the other side of the Atlantic, his Big Apple counterpart needs help to even get home from the airport.

In shoestring

Sen and Munshi



budget movies, where there aren't any stars or production values to distract, the script has to be crackling (recall the recent *Bheja Fry*). Here Dutt is hobbled by his own lumbering script and plodding direction. Much of the film is in English and the dialogues sound like leftovers from American TV. A sampler. A character says, "I want us to make a baby together." The lady

replies, "If you want, we could make a baby together."

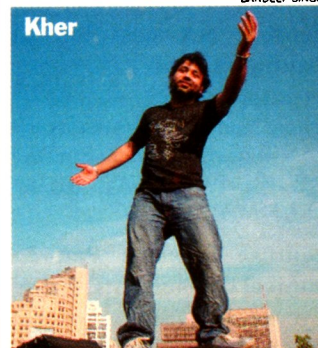
Dutt's film has ambition. He wants to comment on everything: prejudice, alienation, the generation gap, the grim underbelly of the Great American Dream and the importance of one's own culture. The climax is genuinely moving but it is too little, too late. This Bong connection doesn't connect.

by Anupama Chopra

music review

Unique Melody

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JHOOMO RE

There is something that carries an instant appeal about Kailash Kher's

music. It is full-throated, raw, earthy and strikes a chord. *Jhoomo Re* is his second non-filmy album with Naresh and Paresh, one that showcases the gradual progression of lyrics and music for the better and much variety. The opening song *Babam bam* is a folk number that Shiva bhakts sing at *akhadas*. "I keep going back to folk music for inspiration because it is the purest form of music," says Kher.

Saiyyan is a soothing love song with minimal contemporary accompaniment. Kher's voice is that of a lover longing for his beloved. He has been bold to experiment with Amir Khusrau's *Chhap tilak* by composing a different melody around it. "I like to experiment with melodies and create something that I can call my own," he says. *Jhoomo re* is a fast-paced song with lots of rhythmic patterns. What comes across starkly is the use of the harmonium which gives a truly local flavour to the songs. Paresh and Naresh have an imaginative mind and know how to blend eastern and western sounds and yet give that Indian feel. Feel the unique voice.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

Celestial Disaster

MY FRIEND GANESHA

Director: Rajiv S. Ruia
Starring: Ahsaas Channa, Kiran Janjani, Sheetal Shah

Can bad acting be injurious to health? In *My Friend Ganesha*, Upasana Singh, playing the devout maid Gangutai, is a bludgeoning assault on the senses—she shrieks and hams until your pupils hurt. Which is entirely in synch with this deliriously bad movie about a lonely, bullied boy who pleads with Lord Ganesha to be his friend. Ganesha miraculously arrives and then

solves all of the family's problems—the fat bully who tormented the boy suffers divine retribution and even the boy's mother who had been unceremoniously fired from her job is summoned back because the office cannot function without her.

This could have been a fun revenge-of-the-nerd story but director Rajiv S. Ruia makes a mess of it. The animation is tacky, the performances are laugh-



Ganesha falls flat ably bad and the script is too juvenile to engage even a child. Indeed, *My Friend Ganesha* requires some celestial intervention itself.

by Anupama Chopra